which the world is entirely physical. In such a view, the relevant facts about consciousness include these:

1. Consciousness arises from brains.
2. Brains are coherent physical systems.

That's all. ("Coherent" here means "made of mutually interacting parts"; two collections of neurons on two non-interacting branches of the wave function are two distinct brains.) You can extend "brains" to "nervous systems" or "organisms" or "information-processing systems" if you like. The point is that we aren't making extra assumptions about consciousness or personal identity in order to discuss Many-Worlds quantum mechanics; it is a quintessentially mechanistic theory, with no special role for observers or experiences. Conscious observers branch along with the rest of the wave function, of course, but so do rocks and rivers and clouds. The challenge of understanding consciousness is as difficult, no more and no less, in Many-Worlds as it would have been without quantum mechanics at all.

There are many important aspects of consciousness that scientists don't currently understand. That is precisely what we should expect; the human mind generally, and consciousness in particular, are extremely complex phenomena. The fact that we don't fully understand them shouldn't tempt us into proposing entirely new laws of fundamental physics to help ourselves out. The laws of physics are enormously better understood, and that understanding has been much better verified by experiment, than the functioning of our brains and their relationship to our minds. We might someday have to contemplate modifying the laws of physics to successfully account for consciousness, but that should be a move of last resort.

We can also flip the question on its head: If quantum mechanics doesn't help account for consciousness, is it nevertheless possible that consciousness plays a central role in accounting for quantum mechanics?

Many things are possible. But there's a bit more to it than that. Given the prominence afforded to the act of measurement in the rules of standard textbook quantum theory, it's natural to wonder whether there isn't